

Log huts at the Mt Pauna Tourist Village, (right) a traditional meal at a homestay

Benreu, Nagaland

Perched at 1,950 m in the shadow of Mt Pauna, Benreu is named after the *ben* (hoolock) tree that draped the hill and *reu* (river) or the local Kwadi stream that originates here. An old Naga village abandoned six times before being re-established in 1860, it is shaped like the horns of the *mithun*, radiating from a saddle along two ridges. Each of the 14 clans has a *morung* (male dormitory); Lungalang's *morung* is the best. Benreu is the base to climb Mt Pauna (2,550 m), the third highest peak in Nagaland. The 6-km, 2.5-hour trek rewards you with sights of rhododendrons, orchids, *mithun* and birds like Blyth's Tragopan and Naga Wren-Babbler. Travellers often start the hike at night to catch the sunrise from the summit. Stay in log huts at the Mt Pauna Tourist Village (Rs 2,000; call Alieliu, guest house convenor, at 9863366927) or Gumsappe's Homestay (Rs 800, Rs 200-250/person for meals; 9436423408, 9402810142) and explore the village with its memorial stones, old gates and views of the Barak River.



Getting there: Fly to Dimapur and drive 86 km to Benreu; it is 37 km from district headquarters Peren and 65 km from capital Kohima

Dras, Ladakh

On January 9, 1995, Dras recorded the lowest temperature of –60°C, making it the second coldest inhabited place in the world. Thankfully, it's more hospitable in summer with carpets of wildflowers welcoming visitors at Manman Top. In 1999, Dras was the battleground for the Kargil War and the Indian tricolour flutters at the War Memorial, with Tololing Ridge, Tiger Hill and Point 4875 (Batra Top) in the distance. Stay at Hotel D'Meadows Ladakh, run by the affable owner Shamim Qari (from Rs 9,400; 9419176373, *www.dmeadowsladakh.in*). The movie *Shershaah* was shot in and around Dras and producer Karan Johar and crew stayed here. Watch traditional Shina song and dance on the lawns (*inset*) or witness a polo match featuring hardy Zanskari horses at the world's second highest *shagaran* (polo ground).



Hotel D'Meadows Ladakh

Getting there: Fly to Srinagar and drive 151 km to Dras; 271 km from Leh